PART I · WHICH NOTE

Pitch

Every note is higher or lower than another. This part starts with the keyboard you can see and touch, moves to the staff where those keys are written, and ends with the families of notes, scales and keys, that whole pieces are built from.

1 **Keyboard** high and low, the patterns › 2 **Staff** lines, spaces and clefs › 3 **Note names** reading every note › 4 **Sharps and flats** the black keys › 5 **Intervals** the distance between notes › 6 **Scales and keys** notes in families

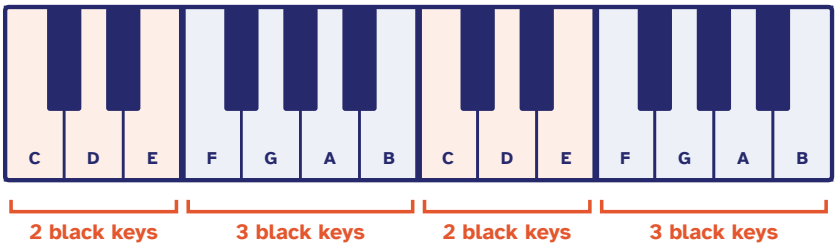
IN THIS PART

The keyboard 22
The staff and the clefs 24
Reading the notes 26
The staff and the keyboard 28
Sharps, flats and naturals 30
Counting intervals 32
Major, minor and perfect 34
Major scales 36
Minor scales 38
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Finding the key 42
The circle of fifths 44

PART I · PITCH · 1

The keyboard

Keys to the **left** sound **lower**; keys to the **right** sound **higher**. The black keys come in groups of **two** and **three**, and that pattern repeats all the way along: it is how you find every note.



The white keys

Seven letters, **A B C D E F G**, then the letters start again, like the days of the week. **C D E** sit around each group of two black keys (C just left of it), **F G A B** around each group of three (F just left of it): the two tints on the picture.

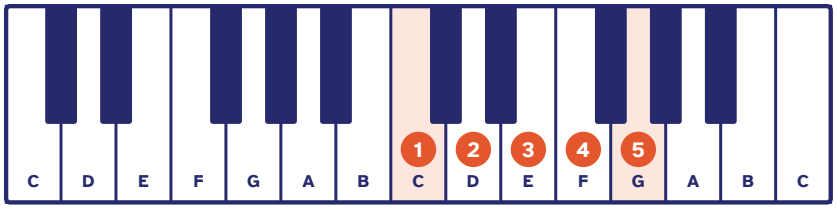
Middle C and octaves

Middle C is the C nearest the middle of the keyboard. From one C to the next is an **octave**: eight white keys, counting both. Octaves are numbered from the bottom: middle C is **C4**, the C below it C3, the C above C5; every key up to the next B shares the number (D4, E4 … B4).

TERM	MEANING	FIRST MET
pitch	how high or low a sound is	Level 0
register	a part of the keyboard: low, middle or high	Level 0
semitone	from one key to the very next key, black or white	Level 0
tone	two semitones	Level 0
octave	from one note to the next with the same name (8 white keys, 12 semitones)	Level 0

IN ACTION

Find G4 on the keyboard



1. **Find middle C (C4):** the C just left of the two black keys nearest the middle.
2. **Count up the letters**, one white key each: C D E F G is five keys.
3. **Same octave**, so the number stays 4.

The key: **G4**. One octave higher, the next G, is G5.

PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED

THINK OF IT The groups of two and three black keys are like the raised bumps on the F and J keys of a computer keyboard: your fingers find their place without looking.

IN REAL MUSIC

The keyboard in all music

RANGE
A full piano has 88 keys, from the lowest A to the highest C: wider than a whole orchestra.

LOW AND HIGH
Composers use the low end for thunder, giants and danger, the high end for birds, stars and sparkle.

OTHER KEYBOARDS
Organ, harpsichord, synthesiser and accordion all share the same pattern of black and white keys.

BLACK KEYS ONLY
Play only the black keys and almost anything sounds good: the five-note pentatonic scale of folk songs worldwide.

Try it. Play the lowest key and the highest key, then find middle C halfway between them.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Eyes closed: find every C on the keyboard by feeling for the groups of two black keys. Then every F, by the groups of three.

LISTEN FOR IT

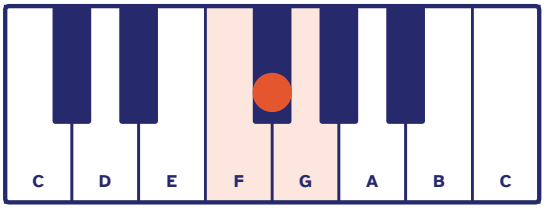
Saint-Saëns, The Carnival of the Animals
Orchestral
The elephant lumbers in the low register; the birds flutter up high.

Chopin, "Black Key" Étude
Romantic piano
The right hand plays almost only black keys.

Amazing Grace
Hymn
The whole tune fits on the black keys.

IN ACTION

Find F♯4



1. **Find F4:** the white key just left of the group of three black keys above middle C.
2. **Sharp means up:** move one key to the right.
3. **The very next key** is black: that is F♯.

F♯4 is the **black key** just right of F4, the first of the group of three.

WATCH OUT

- × Counting octaves from the left end of the piano: octave numbers always change at C, not A.
- × Calling every black key a sharp: each one has a flat name too (p. 30).

SEE ALSO
The staff p. 24 · Staff and keyboard p. 28

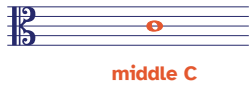
PRACTISE IT
Workbook Pitch 1 · Online: Keyboard patterns

PART I · PITCH · 2

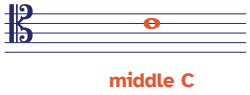
The staff and the clefs

Music is written on a **staff** (or stave) of five lines and four spaces. Lines and spaces are counted from the **bottom**. Higher notes sit higher on the staff. A **clef** at the start tells you which notes the lines and spaces stand for.

CLEF	NAME	HOW IT SHOWS ITS NOTE	FIRST MET
𝄞	**treble clef** (G clef)	curls round the line for G (line 2)	Level 0
𝄢	**bass clef** (F clef)	its two dots sit either side of the line for F (line 4)	Level 0



Alto clef: middle C on line 3. Used by the viola.

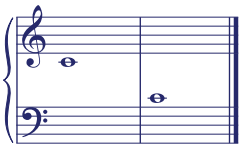


Tenor clef: middle C on line 4. Cello, bassoon and trombone, up high.

Other clefs. C clefs: the line through the centre of the clef is middle C. Piano music never uses them, but pianists meet them in theory exams and when reading the viola or cello part in chamber music or a score (Level 2).

The grand staff

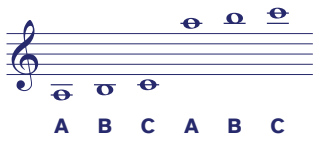
Piano music uses two staves joined by a brace: the treble staff, usually for the right hand, above the bass staff, usually for the left. **Middle C** sits between them on a short line of its own, and can be written in either staff.



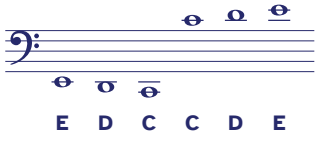
Middle C in the treble staff (left) and in the bass staff (right): the same key.

Ledger lines

Notes above or below the staff sit on short extra lines called **ledger lines**, spaced like the staff lines.



Treble: A, B, C below; A, B, C above.



Bass: E, D, C below; C, D, E above.

Octave signs

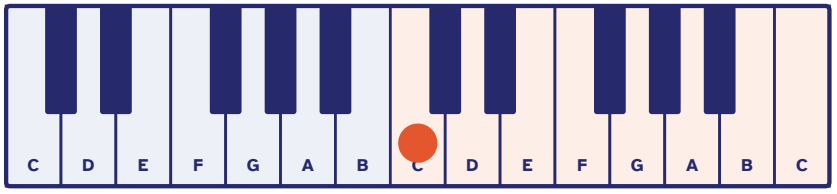
SIGN	MEANING
8va	an octave higher, as far as the dotted line
8vb	an octave lower
15ma	two octaves higher (Level 4)
loco	back where it is written

Level ½. Octave signs save writing many ledger lines.

PART I · PITCH · 2 · CONTINUED

IN ACTION

Which staff does this note belong to?



1. **Below middle C** (blue): the bass staff, usually the left hand.
2. **Above middle C** (pink): the treble staff, usually the right hand.
3. **Middle C itself** (the red dot): either staff, whichever hand plays it.

Low keys: **bass clef**. High keys: **treble clef**. The two staves meet at middle C.

THINK OF IT A clef is the legend on a map: the same lines mean different notes until you know which legend you are reading.

IN REAL MUSIC

Clefs in all music

PIANO MUSIC
Treble and bass together on the grand staff: one staff for each hand.

SONGS AND LEAD SHEETS
Only the treble clef: the melody, with chord names above it.

ORCHESTRA SCORES
Violin and flute in treble, cello and tuba in bass, viola in alto.

GUITAR AND TENOR VOICE
Written in treble but sounding an octave lower: a small 8 under the clef.

Try it. Open any piece you play: which clef does each hand use, and does it ever change?

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Point to five notes in a piece and say “treble” or “bass”, then which hand plays each one.

LISTEN FOR IT

A string quartet
Chamber music
Four players, three clefs: treble, alto and bass.

A church choir
Vocal
Sopranos and altos read treble; basses read bass.

Your own pieces
Piano
Watch for a clef change when the left hand climbs high.

WATCH OUT

- × Reading bass-clef notes as if they were treble: check the clef on every line.
- × Thinking middle C has two keys because it can be written in two places.

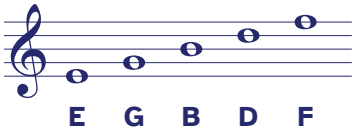
SEE ALSO
Reading the notes p. 26 · The staff and the keyboard p. 28

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Pitch 2 · Online: Library › Staff and clefs

PART I · PITCH · 3

Reading the notes

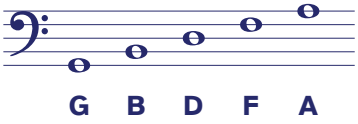
Each line and space has one letter name. Learn them in two ways: by the patterns below, and by a few **landmark notes** you can find instantly and count from.



Treble clef: the lines



Treble clef: the spaces



Bass clef: the lines



Bass clef: the spaces

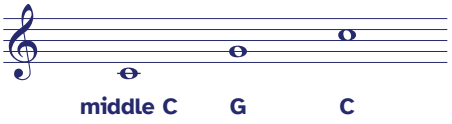
STAFF	NOTES, BOTTOM TO TOP	TO REMEMBER
Treble lines	E G B D F	*Every Good Boy Deserves Fun*
Treble spaces	F A C E	spells *FACE*
Bass lines	G B D F A	*Great Big Dragon Flies Away*
Bass spaces	A C E G	*All Cows Eat Grass*

Landmark notes

Find these first. Every other note is a **step** (line to space) or a **skip** (line to line) away.
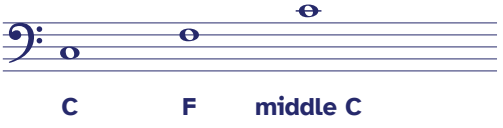
Treble clef

Middle C on its ledger line below; the G the clef curls round (line 2); the C in the third space.



Bass clef

The C in the second space; the F between the clef's dots (line 4); middle C on its ledger line above.



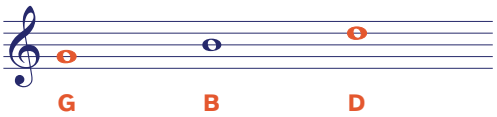
THINK OF IT Landmark notes are like lamp posts on a dark road: walk from one to the next and you are never lost.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Flash cards: one minute, as many notes as you can name. Write your score and beat it tomorrow.

PART I · PITCH · 3 · CONTINUED

IN ACTION

Read a note you are not sure of



1. **The clef:** treble.
2. **A landmark:** the G the clef curls round, on line 2.
3. **Skip up** line to line, one letter jumped each time: G, B, D.

The note on line 4 is **D**.

IN REAL MUSIC

Reading in all music

HYMNS AND CHOIR BOOKS
Four voices on two staves: read up and down as well as left to right.

FAST MUSIC
Good readers see shapes, steps and skips, not every single letter.

POP SHEET MUSIC
The melody on the treble staff with the words underneath.

VERY HIGH AND LOW NOTES
Ledger lines climb off the staff in showy Romantic pieces.

Try it. Before you name the notes of a new piece, trace its shape aloud: “up a step, down a skip, same note”.

LISTEN FOR IT

Bach, Minuet in G (from the Anna Magdalena notebook)
Baroque
Mostly steps: easy to read by shape.

Beethoven, Ode to Joy
Classical
Almost all steps: read it as one rising and falling line.

Mozart, “Twinkle” Variations
Classical
Skips and steps in one famous tune.

WATCH OUT

- × Naming bass-clef notes with treble names: in the bass, the bottom line is G, not E.
- × Counting ledger lines from the wrong end: start from the staff and count outwards.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL In a new piece, read only the landmark notes first, then fill in the notes between them.

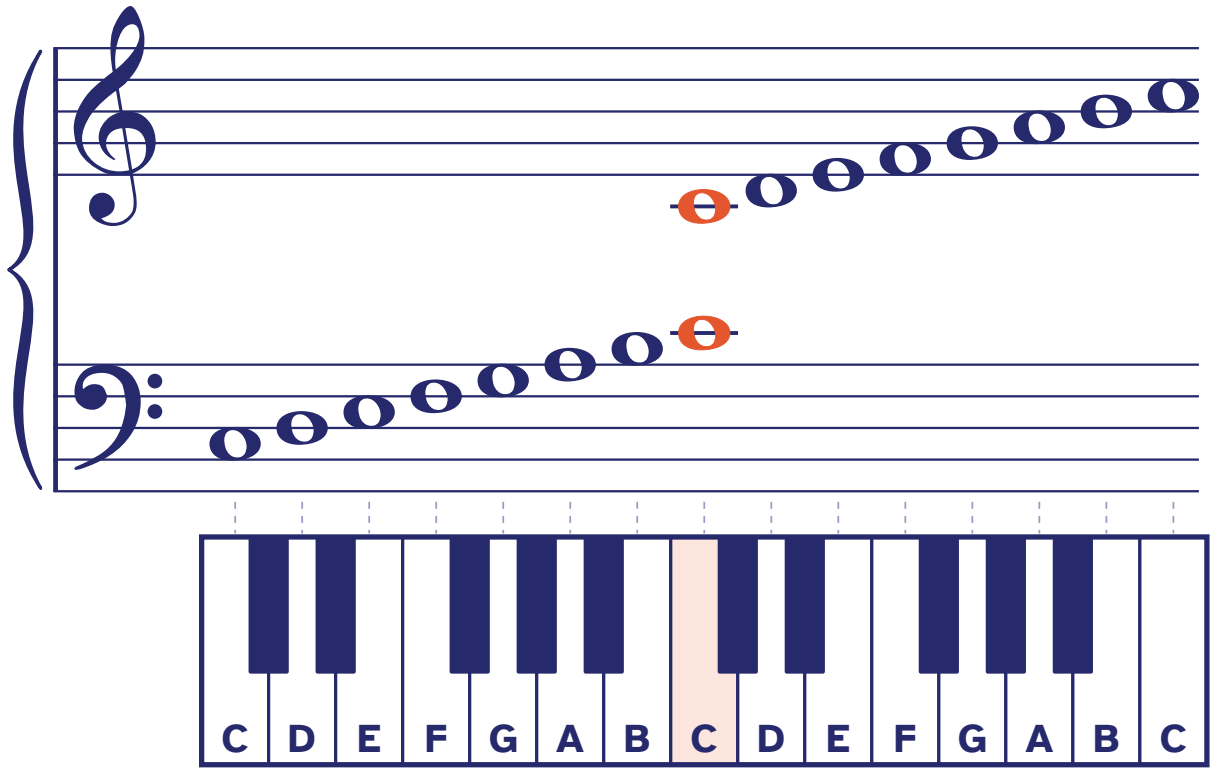
SEE ALSO
The staff and the clefs p. 24 · The staff and the keyboard p. 28

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Pitch 2 · Online: Library › Staff and clefs

PART I · PITCH · 4

The staff and the keyboard

Every line and space of the grand staff is one white key. Read from left to right, the notes climb the staff exactly as the keys climb the keyboard: two octaves from C3 to C5, with middle C in red where the two staves meet.



What the map shows

Each step up the staff (line to space, space to line) is the next **white** key. The black keys have no line or space of their own: they are written with a sharp or a flat on a white key's line or space (p. 30).

Two ways to write one key

Middle C can sit on a ledger line below the treble staff or above the bass staff. Both mean the same key; the music chooses the staff of the hand that plays it.

THINK OF IT The staff is a ladder laid on its side beside the keyboard: each rung, a line or a space, is the next white key.

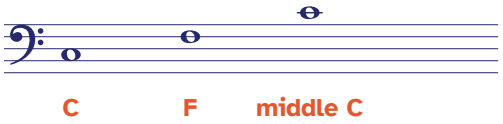
TWO-MINUTE DRILL Close your eyes, say a note name and a staff, then find the key without looking.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Play every C on the keyboard, low to high, and point to each one on the map as you go.

PART I · PITCH · 4 · CONTINUED

IN ACTION

From the page to the key



1. **Name the note on the staff:** line 4 of the bass staff, between the clef's dots, is F.
2. **Count down from middle C:** C B A G F, the fifth white key down.
3. **Play it** with the left hand: that is F3.

The bass-clef F is **F3**, five white keys below middle C.

IN REAL MUSIC

The map in all music

READING AT THE PIANO
Eyes stay on the music; the hands find the keys by distance, not by looking down.

THE ORGAN
The same map, with a third staff for the feet.

EVERY INSTRUMENT
Higher on the page means higher in sound, for voices, violins and trumpets alike.

NOTATION APPS
Many show a keyboard under the staff, just like this map.

Try it. Play C3 to C5 slowly while pointing to each note on the map.

LISTEN FOR IT

Bach, Prelude in C (Well-Tempered Clavier)
Baroque
Broken chords climb and fall across the map.

Debussy, Clair de lune
Impressionist
The whole keyboard, from deep bass to high sparkle.

Joplin, The Entertainer
Ragtime
The left hand leaps between low and middle registers.

WATCH OUT

× Thinking the black keys have their own lines: they borrow a white key's line or space with a sharp or flat.

THINK OF IT Reading music is like reading a map while driving: glance at the page, trust your hands to know the distances.

SEE ALSO
The keyboard p. 22 · Reading the notes p. 26

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Pitch 1–2 · Online: Library › Staff and clefs
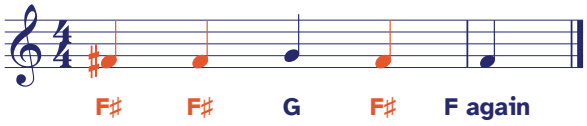
PART I · PITCH · 5

Sharps, flats and naturals

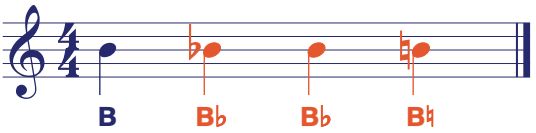
An **accidental** written before a note changes its pitch by a semitone. On the keyboard, a sharp usually means the black key to the right, a flat the black key to the left.

SIGN	NAME	WHAT IT DOES	FIRST MET
♯	sharp	raises a note by a semitone	Level 0
♭	flat	lowers a note by a semitone	Level 0
♮	natural	cancels a sharp or flat	Level ½
𝄪	double sharp	raises by two semitones	Level 4
𝄫	double flat	lowers by two semitones	Level 4

An accidental lasts for the bar



The sharp still counts later in the bar; after the bar line, F is F again.



A natural cancels the flat for the rest of the bar.

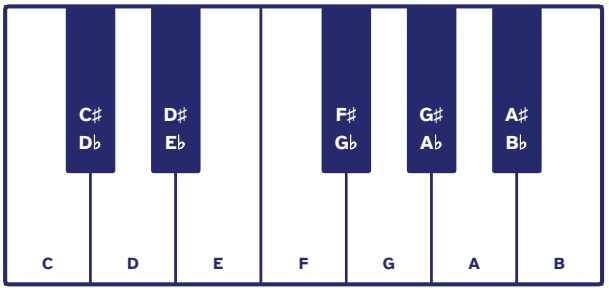
Only that line or space. A sharp on the F in the first space does not change the F an octave higher.

A tie carries it on. A note tied across the bar line keeps its accidental.

Reminders. A courtesy accidental, sometimes in brackets, just reminds you after a bar line.

One key, two names

Every black key has two names: the key between F and G is both **F♯** and **G♭**. Notes that sound the same but are written differently are **enharmonic**. White keys can have sharp or flat names too: **E♯** is F, **C♭** is B.
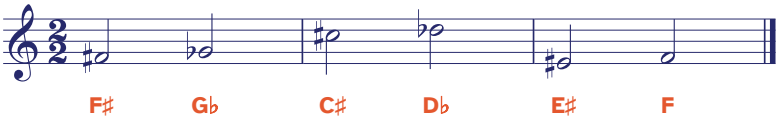


THINK OF IT A key signature is the principal's notice on the school board: it speaks to every student, every day. An accidental is a teacher stopping at one student's desk: the message is for that note only, and it lasts until the next bar line.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL In your piece, circle every accidental, then say how long each one lasts.

PART I · PITCH · 5 · CONTINUED

IN ACTION

One key, two names



1. **The first bar:** F♯, then G♭.
2. **Find them:** both are the black key between F and G.
3. **The last bar:** no black key sits above E, so E♯ is the white key F.

Same key, different names: these are **enharmonic** notes.

IN REAL MUSIC

Sharps and flats in all music

BLUES AND JAZZ
"Blue notes": a flattened 3rd or 7th gives the blues its sound.

ROMANTIC PIANO
Chopin and Liszt are full of accidentals: they pass through other keys within a bar.

FILM MUSIC
One sudden sharp or flat can turn a happy tune into a worried one.

POP SONGS
The last chorus often moves up a semitone: every note rises together.

Try it. Play C D E F G, then again with E♭: listen to the mood change.

LISTEN FOR IT

Gershwin, Rhapsody in Blue
Jazz meets classical
Blue notes everywhere, from the opening clarinet slide.

Chopin, Nocturne in E♭, Op. 9 No. 2
Romantic
Accidentals colour the melody as it decorates itself.

A last-chorus key change
Pop
The whole song lifts a semitone for the final chorus.

WATCH OUT

- × Forgetting that an accidental lasts until the bar line.
- × Carrying an accidental into the next bar: after the bar line, the key signature rules again.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Play F, then F♯, then G♭: hear that the last two are the same key with two names.

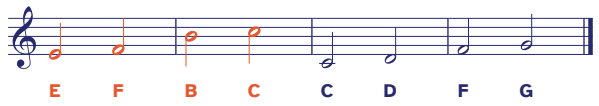
SEE ALSO
Keys and key signatures p. 40

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Pitch 3 · Online: Library › Signs

PART I · PITCH · 6

Counting intervals

An **interval** is the distance between two notes. A **semitone** is the very next key; a **tone** is two semitones. An interval's **number** comes from counting letter names, both ends included.

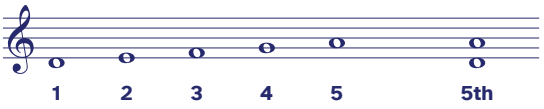


E–F and B–C are semitones; C–D and F–G are tones.



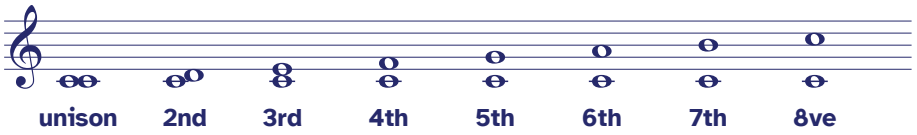
Melodic: one note after the other. Harmonic: together.

Counting the number



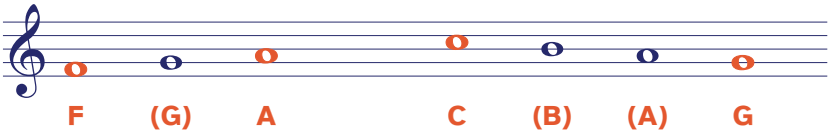
D up to A: D E F G A is five letters, so the interval is a 5th, whether the notes come one after the other or together.

Interval numbers from C



IN ACTION

How far apart are these notes?



1. **Call the first note 1:** F is 1.
2. **Count every letter to the second note:** F G A is 3 letters: a 3rd.
3. **Going down works the same:** C B A G is 4 letters: a 4th.

F up to A is a **3rd**; C down to G is a **4th**. Sharps and flats never change the number.

THINK OF IT Put your thumb on C and your little finger on G: five fingers on five white keys, a 5th. Your hand measures intervals for you.

PART I · PITCH · 6 · CONTINUED

IN REAL MUSIC

Intervals in all music

MELODIES
Most tunes move by small steps (2nds), with a few leaps for drama.

BASS LINES
Rock and pop bass parts often jump by 5ths and octaves.

HARMONY
Chords are built by stacking 3rds on top of each other.

DOORBELLS
Two-note doorbells usually ring a 3rd: ding-dong.

Try it. Sing the first two notes of a song you know, then find that interval on the keyboard.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Play C, then every interval above it up to the octave. Sing each one back before you play the next.

LISTEN FOR IT

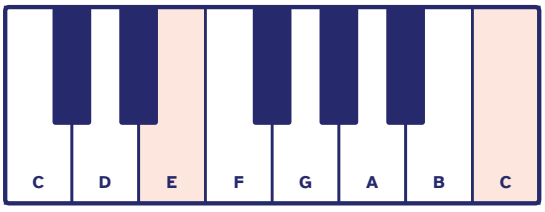
Wagner, Bridal Chorus
Opera
"Here comes the bride": a 4th up on the first two notes.

Williams, Jaws
Film
Two notes a semitone apart, again and again.

Arlen, Over the Rainbow
Song
"Some-where": an octave leap.

IN ACTION

Name an interval on the keyboard



1. **Find both notes:** E and the C above it.
2. **Count the letters:** E F G A B C is six.
3. **Both ends count:** so the interval is a 6th.

E up to C is a **6th**.

WATCH OUT

- × Counting only the gaps, not the notes: always count both ends.
- × Letting a sharp or flat change the number: C to G♯ is still a 5th.

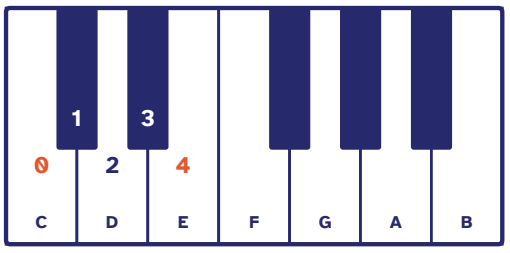
SEE ALSO
Major, minor and perfect p. 34 · Scales p. 36

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Pitch 4 · Online: Library › Intervals

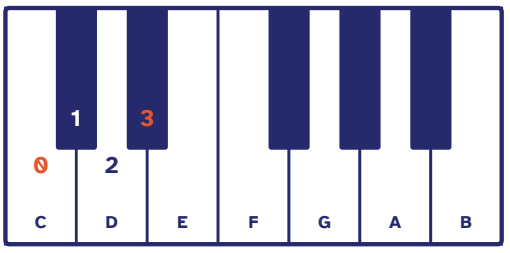
PART I · PITCH · 7

Major, minor and perfect
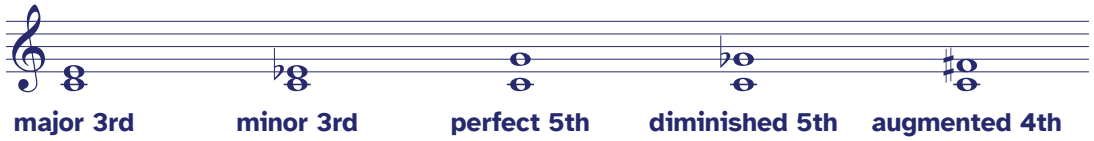
Two intervals with the same number can differ in size. C–E and C–E♭ are both 3rds, but one is a semitone wider. The **quality** (major, minor, perfect…) comes from counting **semitones**.



C to E: count every key, black and white. 4 semitones: a major 3rd.



C to E♭: 3 semitones: a minor 3rd.



Size in semitones

NUMBER	SMALLER	MAIN	WIDER	FIRST MET
unison	0			Level 1
2nd	1 (minor)	2 (major)		Level 1
3rd	3 (minor)	4 (major)		Level ½
4th		5 (perfect)	6 (augmented)	Level 1
5th	6 (diminished)	7 (perfect)		Level 1
6th	8 (minor)	9 (major)		Level 2
7th	10 (minor)	11 (major)		Level 2
octave		12 (perfect)		Level 1

2nds, 3rds, 6ths, 7ths
diminished ‹ **minor** ‹ **major** › augmented

unisons, 4ths, 5ths, octaves
diminished ‹ **perfect** › augmented

Each step on the ladder is one semitone. Six semitones (an augmented 4th or diminished 5th) is the tritone. Turned upside down, an interval's numbers add to 9 and major and minor swap: a major 3rd becomes a minor 6th.

THINK OF IT A major and a minor 3rd are a smile and a frown: the same face, one small change at the corners.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Play a major 3rd up from every white key. Fix the ones that need a sharp or a flat.

PART I · PITCH · 7 · CONTINUED

IN ACTION

Major or minor 3rd?

C up to E♭.

1. **Count the letters:** C D E is three, so it is a 3rd.
2. **Count the semitones:** C to C♯, D, E♭ is three.
3. **Three semitones** make a minor 3rd; four would be major.

C to E♭: a **minor 3rd**.

IN REAL MUSIC

Quality in all music

HAPPY AND SAD
Major 3rds sound bright, minor 3rds darker: the heart of major and minor music.

PERFECT 5THS
Open and strong: rock “power chords” are just a note and its 5th.

THE TRITONE
Six semitones, once called “the devil in music”, now the spice of jazz chords.

FILM
Composers swap a major 3rd for a minor one when the story turns dark.

Try it. Play C–E, then C–E♭: describe each one in a single word.

LISTEN FOR IT

Bernstein, Maria
Musical
“Ma-ri-a”: a tritone that rises to a perfect 5th.

Beethoven, Symphony No. 9
Opening
Bare perfect 5ths, like a world before music.

Rock power chords
Rock
Root and 5th only: strong, neither major nor minor.

WATCH OUT

- × Counting white keys only: count every key, black and white.
- × Calling a 4th or 5th “major”: they are perfect.

HOW TO

Hear the difference

1. **Play C and E together,** then C and E♭.
2. **Sing the top note** of each, then both notes one after the other.
3. **Name the mood** in one word: bright or dark?
4. **Try it from G and from D:** the sound of each quality stays the same.
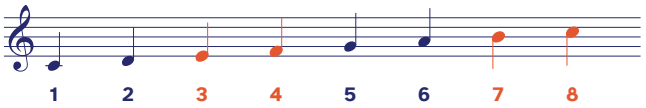
SEE ALSO
Counting intervals p. 32 · Chords: Harmony (later)

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Pitch 4 · Online: Library › Intervals

PART I · PITCH · 8

Major scales

A **scale** is a ladder of notes from one key note up to the next, in a fixed pattern of tones (T) and semitones (S). The pattern, not the starting note, makes a scale major or minor.



C major: T T S T T T S. The semitones fall between 3–4 and 7–8.

SCALE	STEPS	FIRST MET
major	T T S T T T S	Level ½
natural minor	T S T T S T T	Level ½
harmonic minor	T S T T S T+S S	Level ½
melodic minor (up)	T S T T T T S; down as the natural minor	Level 2
chromatic	every semitone	Level 2
pentatonic (black keys)	T T T+S T T+S	Level 0

Degree names

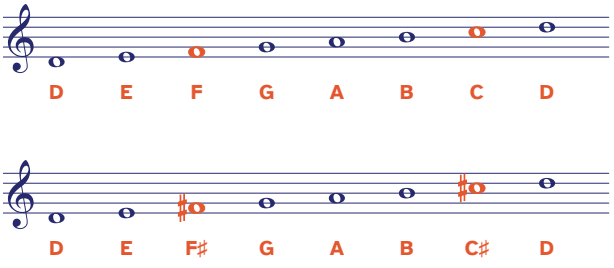
1 tonic · **2** supertonic · **3** mediant · **4** subdominant · **5** dominant · **6** submediant · **7** leading note

Major or minor?

The same key note can start a major or a minor scale: C major and C minor. The pattern decides. Major sounds bright and settled; minor, darker.

IN ACTION

Build D major



1. **Write the eight letters** from D to D, every letter once.
2. **Check the steps** against T T S T T T S: E–F is too small, B–C is too small.
3. **Raise F and C** a semitone to fix them.

D major: **D E F♯ G A B C♯ D**, two sharps.

THINK OF IT A scale is a staircase with two short steps. Wherever you build it, the short steps sit in the same places: between 3 and 4, and between 7 and 8.

PART I · PITCH · 8 · CONTINUED

IN REAL MUSIC

Scales in all music

DO-RE-MI
The major scale, sung: one song from The Sound of Music teaches all of it.

MELODIES
Many tunes are scale fragments: three notes up, four notes down.

PENTATONIC
Five of the seven notes: the sound of folk songs from Scotland to China.

WARMING UP
Pianists, singers and violinists all play scales every day.

Try it. Sing do-re-mi up and down, then play it starting on C, on G and on F.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL One major scale a day, round the circle of fifths: C, G, D, A, E...

LISTEN FOR IT

Rodgers, Do-Re-Mi
Musical
The major scale with words.

Joy to the World
Carol
The tune walks straight down the major scale.

Mozart, Sonata in C, K. 545
Classical
Scales run up and down the first movement.

IN ACTION

Build F major

1. **Write the letters** from F to F: F G A B C D E F.
2. **Check the steps** against T T S T T T S: A to B is a tone, but it must be a semitone.
3. **Lower B** to B♭: now A to B♭ is a semitone and B♭ to C a tone.

F major: **F G A B♭ C D E F**, one flat.

WATCH OUT

- × Using the same letter twice: every letter appears once (F♯, not G♭, in G major).
- × Forgetting the semitone between 7 and 8: the leading note pulls up to the key note.

HOW TO

Practise a scale

1. **Hands separately,** slowly, saying the finger numbers aloud.
2. **Fingering for C, G, D, A and E major** (right hand): 1 2 3, thumb under, 1 2 3 4 5.
3. **Listen for evenness:** every note the same length and loudness.
4. **Then hands together,** one octave, then two.

SEE ALSO
Minor scales p. 38 · Keys and key signatures p. 40
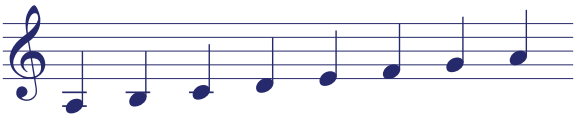
PRACTISE IT
Workbook Pitch 5 · Online: Scale finder, Library › Scales

PART I · PITCH · 9
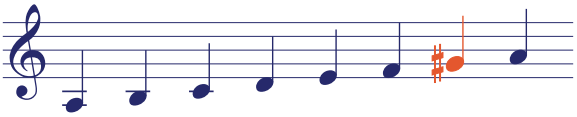
Minor scales

Every minor scale starts from the natural minor, the notes of its relative major from the 6th degree up. Two small changes give the harmonic and melodic forms, which sound stronger at the top.

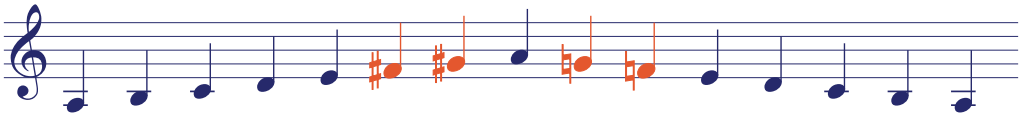
A minor in three forms



Natural: the notes of C major, from A to A. T S T T S T T.



Harmonic: the 7th raised a semitone (**G♯**). The gap F–G♯ is a tone and a half.



Melodic: the 6th and 7th raised going up (**F♯ G♯**), lowered coming down (**G♮ F♮**).

Relative minor

Same key signature, three semitones below the major: C major and A minor share every note.

Parallel minor

Same key note, different signature: C major (no sharps or flats) and C minor (three flats).

THINK OF IT The relative minor is the same clothes worn by a different person: the same notes, a new key note. The parallel minor is the same person in different clothes: the same key note, some notes changed.

IN ACTION

Build E harmonic minor

1. **Borrow G major's notes** starting on E: E F♯ G A B C D E.
2. **Raise the 7th:** D becomes D♯.
3. **Check the gap** C to D♯: a tone and a half.

E harmonic minor: **E F♯ G A B C D♯ E**.

PART I · PITCH · 9 · CONTINUED

IN REAL MUSIC

Minor in all music

FOLK AND BALLADS
The natural minor: the sound of many folk songs and slow pop ballads.

JAZZ
The melodic minor, the same up and down, is called the jazz minor.

CLASSICAL
The harmonic minor: its raised 7th pulls hard towards the key note.

FILM AND GAMES
Minor keys for mystery, danger and sadness.

Try it. Play A natural minor, then A harmonic minor: which one sounds more tense?

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Play A natural, harmonic and melodic minor one after another, naming the notes that change.

LISTEN FOR IT

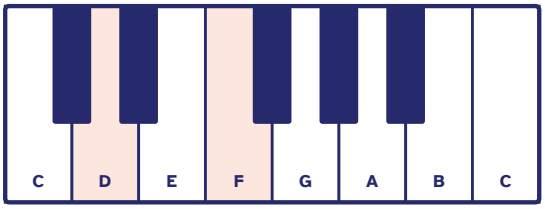
Bach, Toccata and Fugue in D minor
Baroque organ
A minor key at full power.

Grieg, In the Hall of the Mountain King
Romantic
A minor tune that creeps, then races.

Mozart, Symphony No. 40
Classical
G minor: restless from the very first bar.

IN ACTION

Find the relative minor of F major



1. **Start on F,** the key note.
2. **Count three semitones down:** E, E♭, D.
3. **Check the signature:** D minor has one flat, B♭, like F major.

The relative minor of F major is **D minor**.

WATCH OUT

- ✕ Raising the 7th in the key signature: it is written as an accidental each time.
- ✕ Playing the melodic minor's raised notes on the way down.

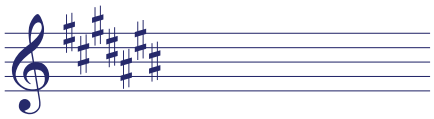
SEE ALSO
Scales p. 36 · Keys and key signatures p. 40

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Pitch 5 · Online: Scale finder, Library › Scales

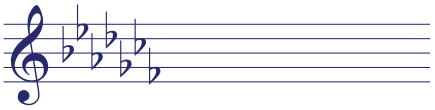
PART I · PITCH · 10

Keys and key signatures

A **key signature** at the start of each line lists the sharps or flats the piece uses throughout, so they do not have to be written before every note. They always appear in the same order.



Sharps: F C G D A E B. The key note is a semitone above the last sharp.

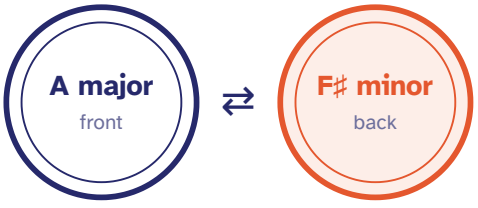


Flats: B E A D G C F. From two flats, the second-last flat names the key.

To remember the order: **F**ather **C**harles **G**oes **D**own **A**nd **E**nds **B**attle; backwards for the flats: **B**attle **E**nds **A**nd **D**own **G**oes **C**harles' **F**ather.

MAJOR	RELATIVE MINOR	SIGNATURE	FIRST MET
C major	A minor	—	Level ½
G major	E minor	1♯	Level ½
D major	B minor	2♯	Level 1
A major	F♯ minor	3♯	Level 3
E major	C♯ minor	4♯	Level 4
B major	G♯ minor	5♯	Level 4
F major	D minor	1♭	Level ½
B♭ major	G minor	2♭	Level 1
E♭ major	C minor	3♭	Level 3
A♭ major	F minor	4♭	Level 4
D♭ major	B♭ minor	5♭	Level 4

Six and seven sharps or flats (F♯, C♯, G♭, C♭ major and their minors) come at Levels 4–6.



One signature, two keys

Every key signature belongs to **one major key and one minor key**, like the two sides of a coin: three sharps are A major or F♯ minor. The minor is the **relative minor**, three semitones below the major.

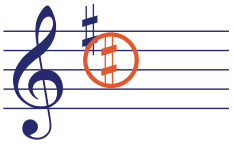
THINK OF IT The key signature is the notice board for the whole piece: every F, in every octave, on every line, follows it. Only an accidental, a word to one note, can overrule it, and only until the bar line.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Each day, name the key of one piece from its signature and its last note.

PART I · PITCH · 10 · CONTINUED

IN ACTION

Name the keys



1. **Count:** two sharps, F♯ and C♯.
2. **The last sharp** is C♯; one semitone up is D.
3. **The relative minor,** three semitones below D, is B.

Two sharps: **D major** or **B minor**.

IN REAL MUSIC

Keys in all music

GUITAR MUSIC
E, A, D and G major are favourites: the open strings ring in those keys.

WIND BANDS
B♭ and E♭ major: the keys brass and wind instruments love.

SONGS
A song is often moved to a new key to suit each singer's voice.

KEY COLOURS
Some composers saw keys as colours: Scriabin heard C major as red.

Try it. Look at five pieces you know: name each key signature and the key it gives.

LISTEN FOR IT

Vivaldi, Spring (The Four Seasons)
Baroque
E major, four sharps: bright and fresh.

Mozart, Eine kleine Nachtmusik
Classical
G major, one sharp: sunny and clear.

Chopin, "Raindrop" Prelude
Romantic
D♭ major, five flats: warm and dark.

WATCH OUT

- × Writing a key signature in the wrong order: sharps always F C G D A E B.
- × Forgetting that a signature names two keys: a major and its relative minor.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Write the order of sharps from memory, F C G D A E B, then the flats, B E A D G C F.

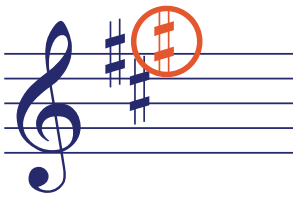
SEE ALSO
Scales p. 36 · Finding the key p. 42 · The circle of fifths p. 44

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Pitch 5 · Online: Scale finder, Library › Keys
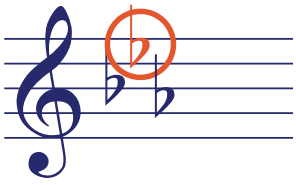
PART I · PITCH · 11

Finding the key

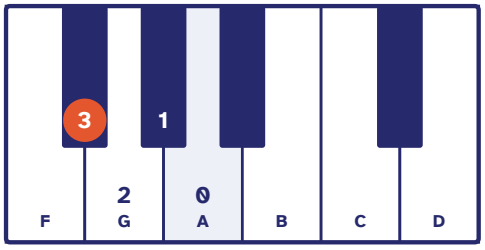
A key signature names two keys, a major and its relative minor. Three quick rules find the major; one more finds the minor; then the music itself tells you which of the two it is.



Sharps: the last sharp, then one semitone up.
Last sharp **G♯** → up a semitone → **A major**.



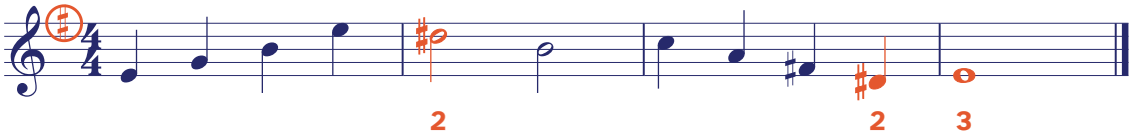
Flats: the second-last flat is the key.
B♭ **E♭** A♭ → **E♭ major**. One flat alone is F major.



Major to minor: three semitones down.
A, G♯, G, **F♯** → **F♯ minor**, the relative minor of A major (count every key, black and white).

IN ACTION

What key is this tune in?



1. **The key signature:** one sharp, so G major or its relative, E minor.
2. **The clue notes:** D♯ keeps appearing. D♯ is the raised 7th of E minor; G major has no D♯.
3. **The last note:** E, the key note of E minor.

The key: **E minor**. Check it the same way with any piece you play.

THINK OF IT The key signature narrows it to two suspects; the clue notes and the last note are the evidence that picks one.

PART I · PITCH · 11 · CONTINUED

IN REAL MUSIC

Finding the key in all music

POP SONGS
Most end on the key note: listen for the chord that feels like home.

MINOR CLUES
A raised 7th, written as an accidental, is the giveaway for a minor key.

SONATAS
They travel to new keys in the middle, then come home at the end.

JAZZ CHARTS
The chord names often tell you the key before a note is played.

Try it. Hum the last note of any song: it is usually the key note.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Take three pieces and find each key in under a minute.

LISTEN FOR IT

Bach, Minuet in G
Baroque
One sharp, ends on G: G major.

Minuet in G minor (Anna Magdalena notebook)
Baroque
Two flats with F♯ clues: G minor.

Beethoven, Für Elise
Classical
No sharps or flats, G♯ clues, ends on A: A minor.

IN ACTION

Major or minor? One flat

1. **The signature:** one flat, so F major or D minor.
2. **The clue notes:** C♯ keeps appearing. C♯ is the raised 7th of D minor.
3. **The last note:** D.

One flat, C♯ clues, ending on D: **D minor**.

WATCH OUT

× Deciding from the signature alone: always check the clue notes and the last note.

Minor keys and their clue notes

MINOR KEY	SIGNATURE	CLUE NOTE (RAISED 7TH)
A minor	none	G♯
E minor	1♯	D♯
D minor	1♭	C♯
B minor	2♯	A♯
G minor	2♭	F♯

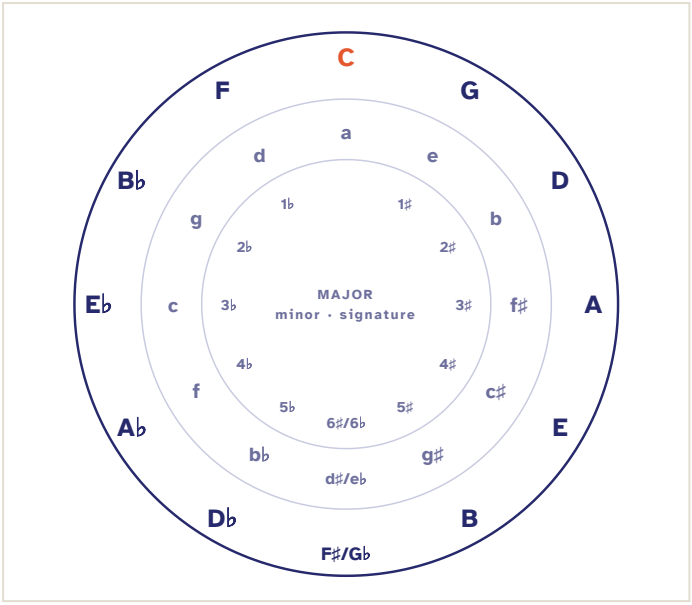
SEE ALSO
Keys and key signatures p. 40 · The circle of fifths p. 44

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Pitch 5 · Online: Scale finder, Library › Keys

PART I · PITCH · 12

The circle of fifths

All the keys on one clock face. Going round clockwise, each key is a **5th higher** than the last and has **one more sharp** (or one fewer flat). Anticlockwise, each is a 4th higher, a 5th lower, with one more flat.



Reading the circle

Outer ring: major keys. **Middle ring:** their relative minors (small letters). **Inner ring:** the key signature.

Neighbours are close

Keys next to each other share all but one note, so music moves between them easily: from C major to G major or F major, or to the relative minor. These are the **related keys**.

Six ways to use it

Key signatures

Count the steps from C: clockwise for sharps, anticlockwise for flats.

Relative minors

Look straight in from any major key.

The main chords

A key's two neighbours give its other main chords: in C, the chords of F and G.

Cadences

The strongest close, V to I, is one step anticlockwise: G to C.

Changing key

Pieces usually move one step round, or to the relative minor.

Scale practice

Go round the circle: one new sharp or flat each time.

IN ACTION

Why do G major and D major sound so close?

1. **Find both:** D is one step clockwise from G.
2. **Compare the scales:** G major has C; D major has C♯.
3. **Count:** six notes the same, one different.

Neighbours share six of their seven notes, so music moves between them easily.

THINK OF IT Like a colour wheel: neighbours blend, opposites clash. C and G sit side by side; C and F♯ sit opposite.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Say the circle aloud, clockwise then anticlockwise, in under twenty seconds.

PART I · PITCH · 12 · CONTINUED

IN REAL MUSIC

The circle in all music

POP CHORD LOOPS
I–V–vi–IV: chords close together on the circle, in countless songs.

JAZZ
Chords that fall round the circle, one step at a time: ii–V–I.

BAROQUE
Sequences walk round the circle, as in Vivaldi's concertos.

CHANGING KEY
Most pieces visit a neighbour on the circle, then come home.

Try it. Play the chords C, G, A minor and F: four chords that sit close together on the circle.

LISTEN FOR IT

Fly Me to the Moon
Jazz standard
Its chords fall round the circle, one after another.

Vivaldi, The Four Seasons
Baroque
Sequences step round the circle.

Pachelbel, Canon in D
Baroque
Eight chords that move between close neighbours.

IN ACTION

Find A major's key signature

1. **Start at C** at the top of the circle: no sharps.
2. **Go clockwise:** G, D, A is three steps.
3. **Three steps,** three sharps: F♯, C♯, G♯.

A major has **three sharps**.

WATCH OUT

- × Going the wrong way round: clockwise adds sharps, anticlockwise adds flats.
- × Forgetting the relative minors on the inner ring.

C major's neighbours

KEY	WHERE ON THE CIRCLE	WHY IT MATTERS
G major	one step clockwise	the dominant: the strongest pull home
F major	one step anticlockwise	the subdominant: a gentle move away
A minor	straight in from C	the relative minor: the same notes
E minor, D minor	in from G and F	the relatives of the neighbours

SEE ALSO
Keys and key signatures p. 40 · Finding the key p. 42 · Chords: Harmony (later)

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Pitch 5 · Online: Scale finder, Library › Related keys

PART II · WHEN, AND FOR HOW LONG

Time

Music moves through time. Underneath it runs a steady **pulse**; the pulse is grouped into **bars**; and every note and rest takes a measured share of it. This part goes from that big picture down to the length of a single note.

1 **Pulse** — the steady beat underneath

› 2 **Bar** — beats in groups of 2, 3 or 4

› 3 **Time signature** — how many beats, and which note is one beat

› 4 **Note values** — how long each sound lasts

› 5 **Rhythm** — the pattern of long and short

IN THIS PART

Pulse, tempo and the bar 48
Notes and rests 50
How long is a note? 52
Time signatures 54
Compound and irregular time 56
Rhythm: groups and upbeats 58
Rhythm: off the beat 60

PART II · TIME · 1

Pulse, tempo and the bar

Under almost every piece runs a **pulse**: a steady beat, like a heartbeat or a clock. Its speed is the **tempo**. Beats are grouped into **bars**, and the first beat of every bar is the strongest.

Tempo

Tempo is measured in beats per minute. A **metronome mark** at the top of the music shows it: ♩ **= 60** means 60 crotchet beats a minute, one beat a second. ♩ **= 120** is twice as fast. Tempo words such as *Andante* and *Allegro* come with Expression, later in the book.

Strong and weak beats

BEATS	PATTERN	FEELS LIKE
2	**Strong** weak	a march
3	**Strong** weak weak	a waltz
4	**Strong** weak **medium** weak	most songs

Bars and bar lines

SIGN	NAME	MEANING
	bar line	divides the music into bars
	double bar line	marks the end of a section, or a change of key, time signature or tempo
	final bar line	marks the end of the piece
	repeat signs	play the passage between them again; if there is no start sign, go back to the beginning

Counting



Three bars of 3/4. Every beat is counted, even inside a long note: the red number is where you play, the grey numbers are the beats you hold.

Count aloud at one speed, a little louder on beat 1. With a metronome, start slower than you think and speed up only when the passage is steady.

WATCH OUT

- × Speeding up in the easy bars and slowing down in the hard ones: choose a tempo you can keep in the hardest bar.
- × Counting the notes instead of the beats.

THINK OF IT The pulse is a heartbeat or a ticking clock: it keeps going even when nothing is played.

PART II · TIME · 1 · CONTINUED

IN ACTION

Is this a march or a waltz?



1. **Tap a steady beat** as you clap or listen.
2. **Find the strong one:** the red beats feel heavier.
3. **Count the gap** between strong beats: 1 2 3, 1 2 3.

Groups of three: a **waltz**, in 3/4. Groups of two would be a march.

IN REAL MUSIC

One pulse, every style

WALTZ · 3 BEATS
The Blue Danube (Johann Strauss II), Chopin's waltzes: strong, weak, weak.

MARCH · 2 BEATS
Sousa's marches: left, right, left, right.

POP AND ROCK · 4 BEATS
Almost every song on the radio: the drummer's kick drum marks beats 1 and 3.

FILM MUSIC · TEMPO AS MOOD
A slow pulse for sadness or awe, a fast one for a chase: the tempo tells the story before the tune does.

Try it. Put on any song and tap your foot. Then find beat 1: it is where the music feels heaviest and the chords usually change.

IN ACTION

Feel the beat before you play



1. **Read the mark:** ♩ **= 96**, 96 crotchet beats a minute.
2. **Listen first:** set the metronome and let one full bar go by, counting "1 2 3" in your head.
3. **Step in** on the next beat 1, the way you step onto a moving escalator.

The first note lands **on the beat**, not a guess.

THINK OF IT To take the plate you want off a sushi train, or to step onto an escalator, you watch the movement first, then move with it at the right moment. Music is already moving before your first note: feel the beat for a bar, then step in.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Walk round the room to a metronome at 60, 90 and 120: a step on every beat, a clap on every beat 1.

LISTEN FOR IT

Ravel, Boléro
Orchestral
One steady pulse for fifteen minutes: only the volume grows.

A ticking clock
Everyday
Sixty ticks a minute: one beat a second, the speed of a slow walk.

Any pop chorus
Drum kit
The snare lands on beats 2 and 4: the backbeat.

SEE ALSO
Time signatures p. 54 · Tempo words: Expression (later)

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Level 0 · Pulse · Online: Metronome

PART II · TIME · 2

Notes and rests

A note's shape shows how long it lasts: each plain note lasts **half as long** as the one above it. Every note has a **rest** of the same length, a silence counted just as carefully as a sound.

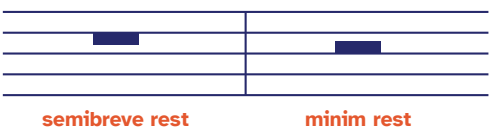
NOTE	REST	NAME	ALSO CALLED	BEATS*	FIRST MET
		breve	double whole note	**8**	Level 4
		dotted semibreve	dotted whole note	**6**	*Extra*
		semibreve	whole note	**4**	Level 0
		dotted minim	dotted half note	**3**	Level 0
		minim	half note	**2**	Level 0
		dotted crotchet	dotted quarter note	**1½**	Level ½
		crotchet	quarter note	**1**	Level 0
		dotted quaver	dotted eighth note	**¾**	Level 3
		quaver	eighth note	**½**	Level 0
		semiquaver	sixteenth note	**¼**	Level 2
		demisemiquaver	32nd note	**⅛**	*Extra*
		hemidemisemiquaver	64th note	**1/16**	*Extra*

* With the crotchet as one beat, as in 2/4, 3/4 and 4/4. *Extra*: beyond Level 8.

Parts of a note

The **head** sits on a line or in a space. A **stem** goes up on the right of the head or down on the left. **Flags** on the stem halve the value each time; groups of quavers are joined by **beams** instead of flags.

Which rest is which?

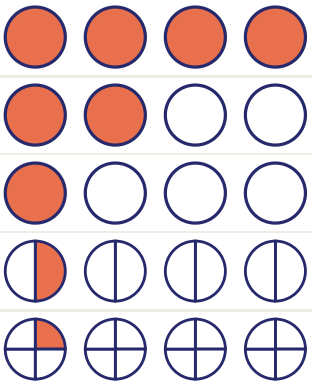


The semibreve rest **hangs** below the fourth line; the minim rest **sits** on the middle line.

PART II · TIME · 2 · CONTINUED

Why whole, half and quarter?

Think of each beat as a pizza. A bar of 4/4 is four pizzas. The note that fills the whole bar is the **whole note**; the others are a half, a quarter, an eighth and a sixteenth of it.



semibreve	whole note	4 pizzas · 4 beats
minim	half note	2 pizzas · 2 beats
crotchet	quarter note	1 pizza · 1 beat
quaver	eighth note	half a pizza · ½ beat
semiquaver	sixteenth note	a quarter of a pizza · ¼ beat

IN ACTION

How long is each sound, and each silence?



1. **Name each shape:** minim, crotchet, crotchet rest.
2. **Count its beats:** 2, 1 and 1.
3. **Count the rests too:** the red rests last as long as their notes.

Every bar adds up to **4 beats**, silences included.

IN REAL MUSIC

Silence is part of the music

CLASSICAL
Beethoven's Fifth Symphony opens with a rest: the famous four notes start just after the beat.

JAZZ
Players say the notes you leave out matter as much as the ones you play.

POP AND FILM
The sudden stop before the last chorus or the big hit: a full bar's rest makes the next sound louder.

DRUMS
Drum notation uses exactly the same notes and rests, on one line.

Try it. In the next piece you play, count every rest aloud and lift your hands off the keys during it.

LISTEN FOR IT

Haydn, "Surprise" Symphony
Classical
The quiet bars set you up; the silence before the bang matters.

Cage, 4'33"
Experimental
A whole piece of rests: the sounds of the room become the music.

Funk and hip-hop grooves
Bass and drums
The gaps between notes make the groove.

THINK OF IT A rest is a breath in a sentence: the words stop, but the meaning carries on. Keep counting through it.
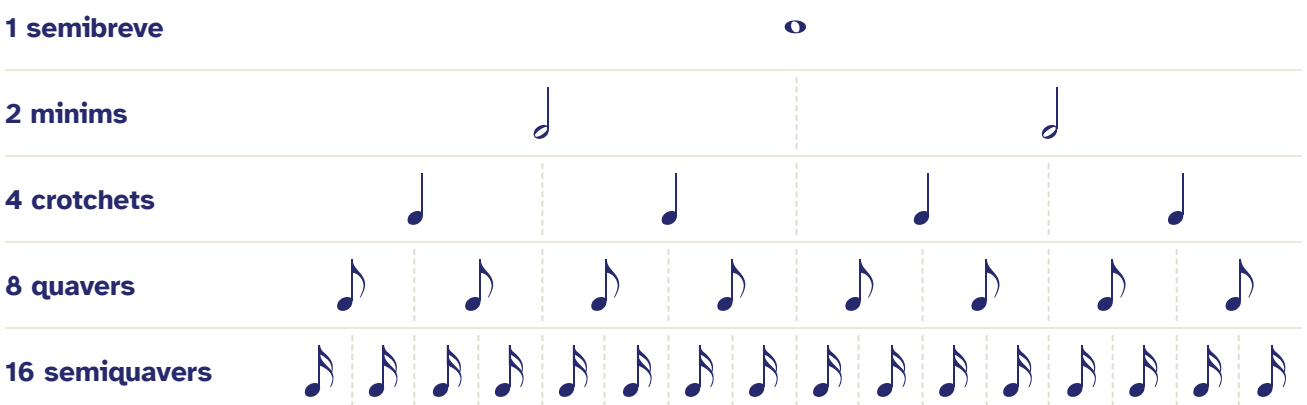
SEE ALSO
Pulse and the bar p. 48 · How long is a note? p. 52

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Level 0 · Note values · Online: Library › Notes and rests

PART II · TIME · 3
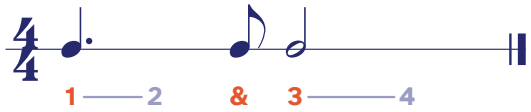
How long is a note?

Each row lasts exactly as long as the row above it: the same stretch of time, cut in half again and again.



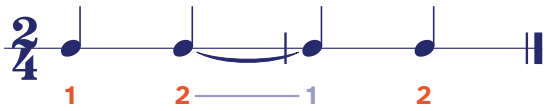
The dot

A dot adds **half the note's value**: a dotted minim lasts 2 + 1 = 3 beats; a dotted crotchet 1 + ½ = 1½. A **double dot** adds half, then a quarter: a double-dotted minim lasts 2 + 1 + ½ = 3½.



The tie

A curve joining two notes **of the same pitch** makes one longer sound: play the first, hold through the second. Ties can cross a bar line, where a dot cannot.



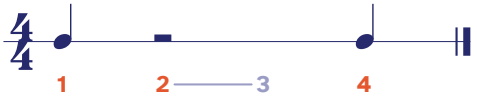
TIE OR SLUR?

The same curve over notes of **different** pitches is a **slur**: play them smoothly joined (legato). Same pitch: a tie. Different pitches: a slur.

Rests in a bar



✓ The silence on beats 3–4 is one minim rest; a whole silent bar takes a semibreve rest, in any time signature.



× In 4/4, a minim rest on beats 2–3 hides the middle of the bar: write two crotchet rests.

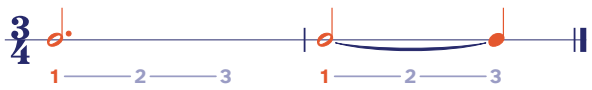
THINK OF IT A tie is a bridge between two notes: you cross it without stopping.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Clap a dotted crotchet and quaver ("long–short") ten times, then clap two even crotchets: feel the difference.

PART II · TIME · 3 · CONTINUED

IN ACTION

Dot or tie: which is longer?



1. **The dotted minim:** 2 + half of 2 = 3 beats.
2. **The tied notes:** a minim tied to a crotchet, 2 + 1 = 3 beats.
3. **Play both:** one sound, held for three beats.

They are **the same length**. A tie can also cross a bar line, which a dot cannot.

IN REAL MUSIC

Long and short, dotted and tied

MARCHES AND ANTHEMS
Dotted rhythms (long–short) give a proud, marching step.

POP AND JAZZ MELODIES
Ties across the bar line let a sung word arrive early, just before the beat.

BAROQUE OVERTURES
Grand openings in French style are full of sharp dotted notes.

LULLABIES
Long tied notes at phrase ends let the music breathe out.

IN ACTION

Count a double dot



1. **The minim:** 2 beats.
2. **First dot:** half of 2 = 1. **Second dot:** half of that = ½.
3. **Add:** 2 + 1 + ½ = 3½, so the quaver after it fills the bar.

A double-dotted minim lasts **3½ beats**.

LISTEN FOR IT

Bach, French Overture style
Baroque
Sharp dotted rhythms: long–short, played crisply.

“Scotch snap” in Scottish folk
Folk
The reverse: short–long, the snap comes first.

National anthems
Ceremonial
Dotted crotchet + quaver gives the lift on key words.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Clap a dotted minim, then a minim tied to a crotchet: the same length, two ways of writing it.

SEE ALSO
Time signatures p. 54 · Rhythm p. 58

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Level 0 · Note values · Online: Library › Notes and rests

PART II · TIME · 4

Time signatures

Two numbers at the start of the music. The **top number** says how many counts are in each bar; the **bottom number** says which note gets one count.

The bottom number

BOTTOM	NOTE	ONE COUNT IS A	FIRST MET
2		minim	Level 3
4		crotchet	Level 0
8		quaver	Level 1
16		semiquaver	*Extra*

SIMPLE OR COMPOUND?

In **simple time** each beat divides into **two**. In **compound time** each beat is a dotted note and divides into **three**.

Quick test: a top number of 6, 9 or 12 means compound. Divide it by 3 to find the beats: 6/8 has 2, 9/8 has 3, 12/8 has 4.

Simple time: each beat divides in two

TIME SIGNATURE	EACH BAR HOLDS	FIRST MET
2/4	2 crotchets	Level 0
3/4	3 crotchets	Level 0
4/4 	4 crotchets (the C sign: common time)	Level 0
2/2 	2 minims (the cut C: cut common time)	Level 3
3/2	3 minims	Level 3
4/2	4 minims	*Extra*
3/8	3 quavers	Level 3

Changing time signature

A new time signature can appear in the middle of a piece, right after a bar line; it holds until the next one. A time signature is written only once, not on every line.

WATCH OUT

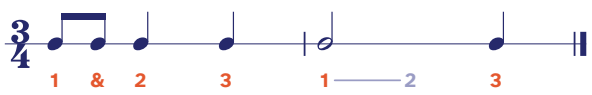
- × Reading 6/8 as six beats: at most speeds it moves in two.
- × Mixing up 3/4 and 6/8: both hold six quavers, grouped differently (page 56).

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Open three pieces you play and read only their time signatures aloud: “three crotchets a bar”, “two dotted crotchets a bar”...

PART II · TIME · 4 · CONTINUED

IN ACTION

Read a time signature



1. **Top number 3:** three counts in each bar.
2. **Bottom number 4:** a crotchet is one count.
3. **Check a bar:** two quavers + crotchet + crotchet = 3.

3/4: **three crotchet beats** in every bar.

IN REAL MUSIC

Time signatures you already know

2/4 · POLKA
Two quick beats: hop, step.

4/4 · COMMON TIME
Most pop, rock, hymns and marches for the classroom.

6/8 · JIGS, LULLABIES
Two swaying beats, each split in three.

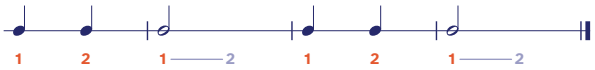
3/4 · WALTZ, MINUET
Three beats: the dance of the ballroom.

2/2 · CUT TIME
Marches and fast pieces: felt in two big beats.

5/4 AND 7/8
Take Five (Brubeck), Mars (Holst), Balkan folk dances.

IN ACTION

Which time signature fits?



1. **Find the strong beats** by clapping, accenting the first note of each bar.
2. **Count each bar:** two crotchets, or one minim: 2 beats.
3. **Each beat is a crotchet.**

It is in **2/4**: two crotchet beats a bar.

LISTEN FOR IT

Tchaikovsky, Swan Lake waltzes
Ballet
Count 1-2-3, but dancers feel one lift per bar.

Brubeck, Take Five
Jazz
Five beats: count 3 + 2 and it settles.

Holst, Mars
Orchestral
5/4 that marches unevenly: 1 2 3, 1 2.

THINK OF IT A time signature is a recipe: the top number says how many spoonfuls, the bottom number which spoon.

SEE ALSO
Pulse and the bar p. 48 · Compound time p. 56

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Level 0 · Time signatures · Online: Library › Time signatures

PART II · TIME · 5
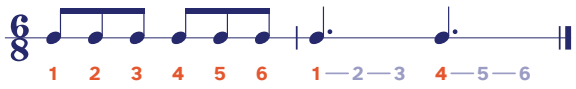
Compound and irregular time

Compound time has dotted beats that divide into three; irregular time has five or seven counts, grouped unevenly. (9/4, 12/4 and the /16 signatures exist but are rare.)

Compound time

TIME SIGNATURE	EACH BAR HOLDS	FIRST MET
6/8	2 dotted crotchets	Level 1
9/8	3 dotted crotchets	Level 3
12/8	4 dotted crotchets	Level 3
6/4	2 dotted minims	Level 4

Counting 6/8



Slowly, count all six quavers. At speed, feel two beats, on 1 and 4: “1 & a, 2 & a”.

3/4 or 6/8?



3/4: six quavers in three twos



6/8: six quavers in two threes

Irregular time

TIME SIGNATURE	EACH BAR HOLDS	FIRST MET
5/4	5 crotchets: 3 + 2 or 2 + 3	Level 5
7/4	7 crotchets: 4 + 3 or 3 + 4	*Extra*
5/8	5 quavers: 3 + 2 or 2 + 3	*Extra*
7/8	7 quavers: 2 + 2 + 3 or 3 + 2 + 2	*Extra*

UNEVEN GROUPS IN 4/4

Many dances keep 4/4 but group the eight quavers 3 + 3 + 2: “1 2 3, 1 2 3, 1 2”.



PART II · TIME · 5 · CONTINUED

IN ACTION

Count 6/8 in two



1. **Slowly, count all six:** 1 2 3 4 5 6.
2. **Lean on 1 and 4**, the red notes.
3. **Faster, count only those:** two beats, each a dotted crotchet.

6/8 has **two beats** in a bar, each split into three.

THINK OF IT Like a skipping rope: two big swings, each with three little steps inside.

IN REAL MUSIC

Uneven and compound beats in real music

6/8 · ROCKING
Row, Row, Row Your Boat; the barcarolles of Offenbach and Chopin, which imitate a gondola.

7/8 · FOLK
Dances from Bulgaria and Greece, counted 2 + 2 + 3.

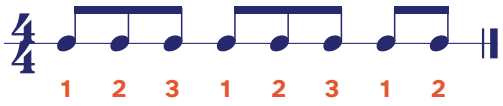
5/4 · LOPSIDED
Take Five (Dave Brubeck), Mars from The Planets (Holst), the Mission: Impossible theme.

3 + 3 + 2 · POP AND LATIN
The bass and drums of countless pop and Latin songs.

Try it. Clap 3 + 3 + 2 (accent the first of each group) along with a pop song in 4/4: it fits.

IN ACTION

Hear 3 + 3 + 2 inside 4/4



1. **Count eight quavers** in a bar of 4/4.
2. **Group them** 3 + 3 + 2, accenting 1, 4 and 7.
3. **Keep the beat** in your foot: it stays in four.

The bar is still **4/4**; only the accents are uneven.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Tap 3 + 3 + 2 on your knees (right hand on each accent) while counting 1 to 8. Then speed up.

LISTEN FOR IT

Offenbach, Barcarolle
Opera
6/8 rocks like a boat: two beats, each split in three.

Bernstein, America
Musical
6/8 and 3/4 take turns: 1-2-3 4-5-6 then 1-2 3-4 5-6.

Latin and pop riffs
Clave, tresillo
3 + 3 + 2 hides inside so many grooves.

SEE ALSO
Time signatures p. 54 · Rhythm: groups and upbeats p. 58

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Levels 2–4 · Compound time · Online: Rhythm clock
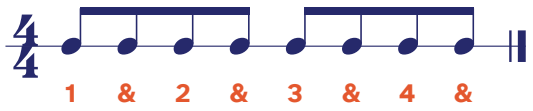
PART II · TIME · 6

Rhythm: groups and upbeats

Rhythm is the pattern of long and short sounds over the pulse. The pulse stays steady; the rhythm moves around it. The way notes are grouped on the page shows where the beats are.

Grouping with beams

Beams join the notes of **one beat**, so the beats stay visible. In 4/4 a beam may cover beats 1–2 or 3–4, but never cross the middle of the bar. In compound time, quavers are beamed in threes.



✓ The middle of the bar can be seen.



× A beam across beats 2–3 hides it.

The upbeat (anacrusis)

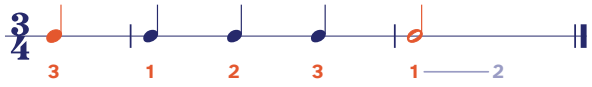
A piece can begin **before** the first full bar, with one or more notes called an upbeat or anacrusis. The last bar is then short by the same amount, so the two together make one full bar. Count the missing beats in silence before you start.



Count “1 2” silently, then play on 3.

IN ACTION

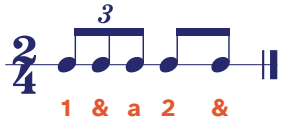
Balance the upbeat



1. **The upbeat:** one beat (count 3) before the first full bar.
2. **The last bar:** only two beats.
3. **Add them:** 1 + 2 = 3, one whole bar of 3/4.
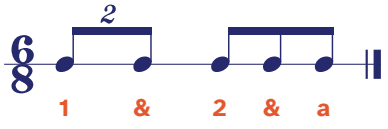
The upbeat and the last bar **make one full bar** together.

Triplets and duplets



Triplet: three notes in the time of two.

Level 2. Three exactly equal notes.



Duplet: two notes in the time of three, in compound time.

Level 2.

PART II · TIME · 6 · CONTINUED

Quavers cut one beat in 2 · a **triplet** cuts it in 3 · **semiquavers** cut it in 4

Counting smaller values



Crotchet, two quavers, four semiquavers and a triplet (“1 & a”): one beat each.

IN REAL MUSIC

Groups and upbeats in pieces you know

UPBEATS
Happy Birthday and Amazing Grace both start before the first strong beat.
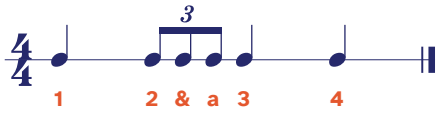
BLUES AND ROCK
A shuffle beat is triplets with the middle one left out.

TRIPLETS
The first movement of Beethoven’s Moonlight Sonata flows in triplets from start to end.

SEMIQUAVERS
The fast running notes of Baroque keyboard music, grouped in fours.

IN ACTION

Fit a triplet into a bar



1. **Count the bar:** four crotchet beats, “1 2 3 4”.
2. **Find the 3:** on beat 2, three quavers share one beat.
3. **Say it:** “1, 2 & a, 3, 4”, keeping beats 3 and 4 steady.

The triplet squeezes three notes into **beat 2**; the beat itself never moves.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Say “trip-o-let, trip-o-let” to a metronome at 60, then clap it. Then play it on one note.

LISTEN FOR IT

Schubert, Erlkönig
Romantic song
Galloping triplets in the piano: a horse riding through the night.

Chopin, Fantaisie-Impromptu
Romantic
Four in one hand against three in the other.

Mendelssohn, Wedding March
Romantic
The trumpets open with a triplet fanfare.

THINK OF IT An upbeat is the breath before you speak: “and-ONE”. You lift on the upbeat so the strong beat can land.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Sing Happy Birthday and clap only on the strong beats: “Hap-py **BIRTH**-day to **YOU**”. The first two syllables are the upbeat.

SEE ALSO
Notes and rests p. 50 · Rhythm: off the beat p. 60

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Levels ½–4 · Rhythm · Online: Rhythm clock

PART II · TIME · 7

Rhythm: off the beat

Once the pulse is secure, rhythm can pull against it. Every one of these effects needs a steady beat underneath.

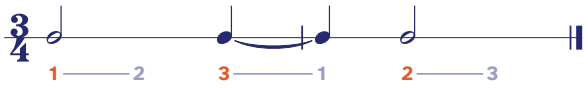
Syncopation



The crotchet starts on “&” and is held through beat 2.

Level 4. Feel beat 2 even though nothing is played on it.

Hemiola



Two bars of 3/4 felt as three minims.

Level 4. Common at cadences in Baroque dances.

Swing Level ½

Common from the first pieces: jazz, blues and many easy modern pieces are marked *swing*. Pairs of quavers are written evenly but played **long–short**, like the first and last notes of a triplet.

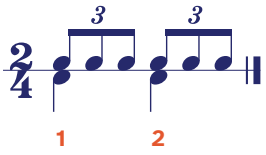


Written



Played

Polyrhythm Level 7



Three against two: a triplet above, two crotchets below, starting together.

Rubato Extra

Time is stretched and then given back, for expression: the music leans into a phrase and catches up after it. The pulse always returns. Marked *rubato*, or simply part of the style in much Romantic music.

WATCH OUT

- × Rushing the short notes after a long one: keep counting inside the long note.
- × Playing a triplet unevenly: three equal notes, not two quick and one long.
- × Letting syncopation drag the pulse: tap the beat with your foot.

THINK OF IT Syncopation is a step that lands between the beats, like a skip in your walk.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Say “doo-ba, doo-ba” in a lazy long–short, then play a C major scale up and down in swing quavers.

PART II · TIME · 7 · CONTINUED

IN ACTION

Count a syncopation



1. **Tap the beats:** 1, 2.
2. **Find the red crotchet:** it starts on the "&", between the beats.
3. **Hold it through beat 2**, then play bar 2 on the beats.

The accent falls **off the beat**: that is syncopation.

IN REAL MUSIC

Off the beat, everywhere

RAGTIME
Scott Joplin's The Entertainer: syncopated right hand over a steady left hand.

JAZZ AND BLUES
Swing quavers: written even, played long–short.

MUSICALS
America from West Side Story (Bernstein) switches between two and three beats: a hemiola you can sing.
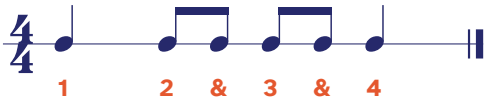
ROMANTIC PIANO
Chopin's melodies lean and pull against the beat: rubato, with the left hand keeping time.

Try it. Tap a steady beat with your foot and clap on the "&"s only. Then try the first bars of The Entertainer.

IN ACTION

Swing this bar

Swing



1. **Find the quaver pairs:** beats 2 and 3.
2. **Play each pair long–short:** "doo-ba, doo-ba".
3. **Leave the crotchets alone:** beats 1 and 4 stay as written.

Only the **pairs** swing; the beat underneath stays even.

LISTEN FOR IT

Ellington, It Don't Mean a Thing
Jazz
"If it ain't got that swing": the title says it all.

Miller, In the Mood
Big band
Swing quavers from the very first bar.

Chopin, Nocturne in E♭, Op. 9 No. 2
Romantic
Rubato: the melody leans, the left hand keeps time.

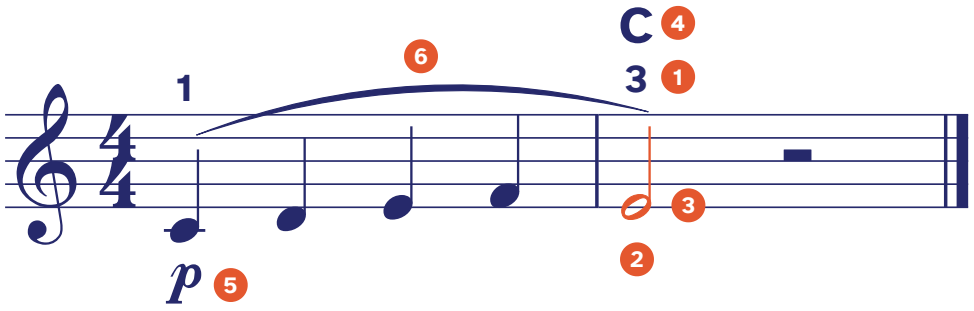
SEE ALSO
Notes and rests p. 50 · Words for how to play: Expression (later)

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Levels ½–4 · Rhythm · Online: Rhythm clock

TIPS · 1

Everything one note tells you

Look at the red note. It carries six pieces of information at once, and each one can be read straight off the page. Read all six and the note is right; miss one and it is only nearly right.



1 The finger number

3: the middle finger plays it. Fingering is planned, not guessed.

PLAYING AND LISTENING (LATER)

2 The beat

Beat 1 of bar 2, and it is held for **two beats**.

PART II · TIME · P. 48

3 The note name

E: the white key just right of the two black keys.

PART I · PITCH · P. 22

4 The chord

The **C** above the staff: this E belongs to the C major chord.

HARMONY (LATER)

5 The marks

p and the slur: play it softly and smoothly.

EXPRESSION (LATER)

6 The phrase

The slur ends here, so the note lands gently, like the end of a sentence.

SHAPE AND STYLE (LATER)

THINK OF IT A note is like a word said aloud: its spelling, its timing, its tone of voice and its place in the sentence all change what it means.

THE SAME SIX, IN ANY MUSIC

A CLASSICAL SCORE

Most of it is written in: finger numbers, dynamics, slurs. Your job is to read every one.

A POP LEAD SHEET

A melody and chord names only. You choose the fingers, the marks and the shape yourself.

A JAZZ CHART

Chords and a style word such as Swing: the beat and the shape are yours to feel.

Try it on any piece: point to one note and find all six. Finger numbers count as much as the note name.

TIPS · 2

When a passage won't come right

Name the problem first, then fix that one thing. Most hard bars are hard for one reason, and the six things a note tells you point straight to it.

TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
You stumble in the same place every time	**the finger number**	Playing and listening
It rushes, drags or the counting slips	**the beat**	Part II · Time
A note sounds wrong	**the note name**	Part I · Pitch
A chord sounds odd or thin	**the chord**	Harmony
It is correct but flat and dull	**the marks**	Expression
It does not seem to go anywhere	**the phrase**	Shape and style

Five ways to fix a hard bar

1. **Slow it right down**
   Slow enough to be right three times in a row, then a little faster.
2. **Hands separately**
   Each hand on its own until it is easy, then together, slowly.
3. **Start from the end**
   Play the last beat, then the last two, then three: you always finish on what you know best.
4. **Practise the join**
   The last note of one bar and the first of the next: most slips live there.
5. **Climb the metronome**
   Up four clicks each time it is clean; down eight if it falls apart.
6. **Put it back**
   Play two bars before and two after, so the fixed bar lives inside the music again.

Before you play a new piece: a thirty-second look

Key signature
Which sharps or flats, all the way through?

Time signature
How many beats in a bar, and which note is one beat?

Tempo and mood
The words at the top: how fast, what character?

Patterns
Bars that repeat or nearly repeat: learn them once.

THINK OF IT Like a doctor: name the symptom first, then treat that one thing. Practising everything harder rarely fixes the one bar that is wrong.